

INSIDE A MULTI-CITY PUSH FOR GLAUCOMA SCREENING

The difference between losing sight and saving it often comes down to access. 'The silent thief' - glaucoma is one of the most under-detected causes of irreversible vision loss. Often with no symptoms in its early stages, the condition quietly damages sight until it is too late.

Sightsavers India and AbbVie Therapeutics India Pvt Ltd have been working together to make glaucoma conversation a public health priority. Conceptualised in 2025, the campaign spanned across 5 States **Bhubaneswar (Odisha), Lucknow (Uttar Pradesh), Bhopal (Madhya Pradesh), Bengaluru (Karnataka)** and **Patna (Bihar)** with a culmination at the National Level in Delhi. Across these sectors, we held consultations and dialogues that brought together policymakers, clinicians, media and communities to spotlight gaps in awareness, early detection and access to care, along with free screenings and referrals.

2026 is different. Our partnership is driving on-ground glaucoma screening and awareness across urban clusters. Our role centres on **planning, coordinating, and finalising screening schedules** with government health facilities and the implementing team.

Since 2025, we have conducted camps in three cities:

Bhopal, Patna and Kanpur

- 28 screening camps conducted
- 1,401 people screened for glaucoma, with 53% women
- 52 suspected cases identified and referred for further care

In Bhopal, outreach has focused on mobilising communities and frontline health workers and activating screenings through government Health and Wellness Centres and Mobile Vision Centres. In Patna, partnerships with Urban Primary Health Centres (UPHCs), hospitals and ward counsellors have strengthened outreach and referral pathways ahead of camps. In Kanpur, sustained community engagement across urban clusters is driving early detection and informing future eye health interventions.

Each camp brings free screening, counselling and referral pathways closer to communities, especially people above 40, because early detection should not depend on where you live. This is prevention, delivered on the ground.

The three-city model has proven one thing: when screening is embedded in existing public health infrastructure and delivered through trusted local health workers, people show up.

As the campaign moves forward in 2026, the focus is on deepening on-ground presence and strengthening referral linkages with government facilities.

Additionally, this year, we will also hold Consultations in 2 cities- Ahmedabad, Gujarat and Jaipur, Rajasthan. At the consultation held in Ahmedabad, the panel members



emphasised the need for stronger public awareness, integration of glaucoma screening into primary healthcare and vision centres, capacity building of eye care personnel, and improved patient counselling to ensure adherence to lifelong treatment, alongside greater collaboration across government, NGOs, academia, and eye care organisations.

What role did rural outreach play in shaping the campaign's success?

Suresh Pattathil, Managing Director and General Manager, AbbVie India: Rural outreach showed us that delay in quality eye care is due to barriers in access like distance from services, limited awareness and the cost of seeking care. In 2025, outreach efforts translated into scale: over 5000 people were screened across 27 camps and consultations, followed by 139 additional camps reaching more than 16,000 people. Thousands received refraction services, spectacles and cataract referrals. These insights shaped the 2026 approach bringing screening closer to communities and strengthening referral pathways.

RN Mohanty, CEO of Sightsavers India: Having worked in the development sector for over three decades, I have consistently seen that preventable blindness is most prevalent where access is weakest. Since 1970, Sightsavers India has prioritised last-mile delivery. Rural outreach reaffirmed that services must go to people, especially those over 40, rather than waiting for them to seek care. Early detection improves significantly when screening is embedded locally.

How can CSR and government schemes accelerate glaucoma screening nationally?

Suresh Pattathil, Managing Director and General Manager, AbbVie India: CSR can enable faster scale by supporting screening equipment, outreach and technology adoption. Government schemes provide the backbone for continuity and integration into public health systems. When both align, screening moves from isolated projects to sustained service delivery. The goal is to strengthen public systems, not run parallel ones.

RN Mohanty, CEO of Sightsavers India: India has strong public programmes for blindness control. CSR can act as catalytic capital, piloting models and addressing immediate gaps. But long-term impact depends on strengthening government systems. Development work teaches us that parallel structures do not sustain; institutional integration does.

How can partnerships like this help build sustained behaviour change around regular eye check-ups?

Suresh Pattathil, Managing Director and General Manager, AbbVie India: From a corporate perspective, sustained behaviour change requires consistency, credibility and scale. Partnerships allow us to move beyond isolated messaging and create repeated, visible engagement around preventive eye health.

When the private sector collaborates with credible civil society organisations and aligns with public systems, it reinforces the importance of routine screening as part of responsible health behaviour.

RN Mohanty, CEO of Sightsavers India: When the private sector steps forward alongside civil society and government, it signals that preventive eye health is a shared responsibility. That collective ownership is what helps shift behaviour from episodic check-ups to regular screening, especially for people over 40. Communities adopt preventive practices when services are reliable, repeated and locally accessible. When screening is delivered through familiar government platforms and community workers, regular eye check-ups begin to feel normal rather than urgent.

What key learnings from this campaign could be applied to similar eye health initiatives across India?

Suresh Pattathil, Managing Director and General Manager, AbbVie India: Awareness must be paired with access i.e information alone does not change outcomes. Strong referral pathways are as important as screening. Data-driven planning helps improve outreach in real time. We focus on indicators that matter- suspected cases identified, referrals completed and diagnostic accuracy. Programmes work best when embedded within government systems, ensuring continuity beyond project cycles and lasting impact.

RN Mohanty, CEO of Sightsavers India: The most important learning is that sustainable impact comes from government partnerships and collaboration across sectors. Screening initiatives must align with state health priorities, integrate into existing facilities and build local capacity to ensure continuity beyond project timelines. Multi-stakeholder collaboration- government, corporate and civil society creates scale, accountability and long-term ownership. That is how short-term campaigns evolve into sustained public health outcomes.

